

Brain food: Building a winning mindset

The brain is a fatty organ — literally. About 60 per cent of its structure is fat, which means good fats are essential for keeping it running smoothly. Omega-3 fatty acids, especially DHA, are the brain's MVP. They're critical for memory, focus, and reaction speed.

Where to find Omega-3:

- ✦ Fatty fish: Salmon, sardines, and mackerel.

- ✦ Plant-based sources: Chia seeds, flax seeds, and walnuts.

- ✦ Fortified foods:

Omega-3-enriched eggs and dairy are great add-ons.

Omega-3s also combat inflammation, which can make you feel mentally sluggish. Think of these fats as oiling the gears of your mental machine.

What to avoid:

- ✦ Sugary energy drinks: They cause spikes and crashes.

- ✦ Processed snacks: High in trans fats, they impair brain function.

- ✦ Alcohol: Even small amounts can disrupt focus and sleep.

Research shows that diets high in sugar can lower levels of brain-derived neurotrophic factor (BDNF), a protein essential for memory. Meanwhile, trans fats in processed foods can slow down brain communication, leaving you struggling to calculate your next move.

Nutrition trends chess players should know about

1. Intermittent fasting: Trending among cognitive athletes, intermittent fasting promotes mental clarity and focus. By giving the brain more access to ketones, it may improve endurance during tournaments.

2. Nootropic foods: Curcumin (from turmeric), walnuts, and matcha are gaining attention for their brain-enhancing benefits. Turmeric lattes before a game, anyone?

3. Hydration matters: Even mild dehydration can impair cognitive performance. Keep sipping water or try green tea for its hydrating and antioxidant benefits.



Genetics: Cracking the code of peak performance

Here's where things get fascinating. What if your genes could tell you exactly what your brain needs to thrive during a chess match? Welcome to the world of nutrigenomics — the science of how food interacts with your DNA.

For instance, some people metabolise caffeine quickly, benefiting from a mental boost. Others process it slower, leading to jitters and focus issues. Likewise, genetic variants may affect how well your body absorbs Omega-3 or processes glucose, directly impacting brain performance.

Take Magnus Carlsen for example, who reportedly avoids high-carb meals before matches because they make him sluggish. What if you knew, down to your DNA, how to tailor your meals for ultimate focus?

Genetic testing can offer personalised insights, allowing chess players to fine-tune their diets and eliminate guesswork. It's not about "hacking" your brain; it's about understanding it better.

Tournament-day nutrition hacks

1. Breakfast like a pro: Start your day with a mix of protein, healthy fats, and complex carbs. Eggs with avocado and whole-grain toast can sustain energy.

2. Snack strategically: Dark

Silent stress: The wild claim that chess players burn 6,000 calories a day during tournaments is a fun headline, but it doesn't add up. While intense mental activity does burn more energy than resting, it's far less dramatic than the myth suggests. FIDE / ENG CHINA

chocolate, nuts, and berries are great mid-game snacks to keep your brain fuelled.

3. Stay hydrated: Aim for at least 2-3 litres of water daily. Add a squeeze of lemon or a pinch of Himalayan salt for electrolytes.

4. Avoid the crash: Skip heavy, greasy meals before matches. Instead, go for something light, like a quinoa salad with lean protein and olive oil.

Conclusion

Chess is more than a game; it's a test of endurance, focus, and mental agility. And while practice and strategy are non-negotiable, the right diet could be your ultimate secret weapon. From smashing calorie myths to exploring the cutting-edge role of genetics, it's clear that nutrition isn't just about fuelling your body — it's about sharpening your mind.

So, the next time you sit down at the board, ask yourself: is your brain getting the checkmate-worthy fuel it deserves? Remember, the board may be static, but your brain — your most important piece — never stops moving. Make every bite count.